

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

JUST A FRIENDLY CHAT?

Several senior Congress leaders are upset with the timing of **Rahul Gandhi**'s interview with filmstar **Kamal Haasan**, which was released on January 2. The conversation focused on Tamil culture, as the Bharat Jodo Yatra crosses North India. Congress insiders feel that Haasan, whose party Makkal Needhi Maiam had a disastrous outing in 2021, is likely to gain more from the interview, as he has been trying to join the DMK-led alliance in Tamil Nadu, which includes the Congress. Rahul's backers say a strong alliance with the DMK makes Tamil Nadu an important state—in 2019, of the 52 Congress Lok Sabha MPs, eight came from Tamil Nadu. Speculation is rife that Haasan may even merge his party with the Congress and become its face in Tamil Nadu.

A FLYING RUMOUR



Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) leader **Ajit Pawar**'s earlier dalliance with the BJP that saw him take charge as the deputy chief minister of Maharashtra in a three-day long government in November 2019 still intrigues many. Pawar is now leader of the Opposition, and rumours continue about his behind-the-scenes bonhomie with the BJP. In December, Pawar air-dashed to Mumbai from Nagpur, where the winter session of the assembly was under way, to welcome senior NCP leader Anil Deshmukh, who was released on bail in an alleged corruption case. What had tongues wagging was the Shinde-BJP government's decision to let Pawar travel by the state's official aircraft. What's cooking?

Cold Vibes

Samajwadi Party chief **Akhilesh Yadav**, who earlier said that he was not invited to join the Uttar Pradesh leg of the Bharat Jodo Yatra, has now conveyed his best wishes to Rahul Gandhi for the same on Twitter. However, he won't take part in it. Nor will any other SP leader. Congress functionaries in UP claim that ties will improve before the Lok Sabha election, but sources close to Akhilesh say he is annoyed with the Congress for two reasons. One, nobody from the Gandhi family attended his father Mulayam Singh Yadav's funeral in October. And two, the memory of the party's unfruitful alliance in the 2017 assembly polls remains all too fresh.



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Broadening Base

Chasing dreams of a pan-India presence, Bharatiya Rashtra Samithi (BRS) chief and Telangana CM **K. Chandrashekar Rao** is extending his footprint first in Andhra Pradesh. He has picked ex-bureaucrat T. Chandrashekar, a political lightweight, to head the party there. In contiguous Karnataka, where his electoral strength will be tested earlier, he plans to join hands with Janata Dal (Secular) to contest seats with a big Telugu presence. KCR is yet to spell out BRS's national agenda though.

NO WINTER BREAK IN BIHAR



If Rahul Gandhi in a T-shirt during the winter chill is making news, Bihar chief minister **Nitish Kumar's** enthusiasm to work in freezing weather is making his babus sweat. On January 2, when the mercury dipped below normal in Patna, Nitish was ready for his *janata durbar*. But some of his bureaucrats were not. When one arrived late, Nitish greeted him sarcastically with folded hands: "*Aa gaye aap? Bada swagat hai aapka* (Oh, you are here? A big welcome)." He then turned to his team and quipped: "Are all of you late today?" From January 5, Nitish also began his pan-Bihar *yatra*, giving his officials no respite from the cold.

Kaushik Deka with Dhaval Kulkarni, Prashant Srivastava, Amarnath K. Menon and Amitabh Srivastava